PASSWORD QUEST · TEACHER MATERIALS · SAMPLE LESSON 2

Email Detective: spot the scam

Students learn to recognize a scam email (phishing), to find out where a link really goes, and to know what to do when a suspicious message arrives or when someone falls for one.

GRADE	LENGTH	SUBJECT	FORMAT
ages 9–15	45 minutes	computing, form time	whole class, pairs

Learning goals

By the end of the lesson, students can:

- name at least three signs of a scam message (rushing and scaring, a prize, a request for a password or details, a strange link, an unexpected attachment),
- find the real domain in a web address (right before the first slash),
- decide whether a message is safe or a scam and explain why,
- respond correctly: don't click, check another way, report it and tell an adult.

Materials

- Projector and teacher computer. Student computers or tablets (one per pair is enough).
- The Password Quest app: the **Email Detective** menu.
- Worksheet (page 3), one per student.

> **Important:** all messages, names and addresses in these materials and in the app are made up (`.example` and `.test` domains). Do not open real scam emails or links in class.

Lesson plan

Time	Activity	What the teacher and students do
5 min	**Warm-up: you won a tablet!**	Project the email from the worksheet (task 1) or read it aloud. Ask: "Who would click? Why or why not?" Let students vote without judging.
8 min	**Signs of a scam**	In pairs, students circle everything suspicious in task 1. Build a list of signs on the board together (box below). Stress that logos and familiar names can be copied; what matters is **what the message wants**.
7 min	**Where does the link go?**	Explain the rule: the real domain comes right before the first slash after `https://`. Show `https://school.example/timetable` and `https://school.example.timetable-online.test/` on the board. Students do task 2.
15 min	**Email Detective in the app**	Students play missions in the **Email Detective** menu. Suggested level: ages 9–10 *Watch for the Bait* (easy), ages 11–12 *Link Checkers* (medium), ages 13–15 *Inbox Analysts* or *Email Detectives*. The key activity is the **inbox**: students open each email and decide "safe" or "scam".

7 min	**What do I do when…**	Go through the situations in task 3 together. Stress that anyone who falls for a scam should not feel ashamed but should tell an adult right away. Report scam messages; don't forward them or reply to them.
3 min	**Exit ticket**	Students complete task 4 and hand it in on the way out.

Signs of a scam email (write on the board):

1. **Rushing and scaring:** "We will block your account within an hour!"
2. **A tempting prize or gift** for a click or your details.
3. **A request for a password, a text-message code or card details.** Schools and trustworthy services never ask for these in a message.
4. **The link goes to a strange domain**, even if its text looks right.
5. **An unexpected attachment**, especially a program (`.exe`) or a document that wants you to "enable macros".
6. **A request for secrecy:** "Don't tell anyone about this."

Adapting for age

Younger students (ages 9–10)

- Skip task 2 (addresses) or do only the first two rows together.
- Talk about "bait": the message wants to hook us like a fish.
- Main rule: if a message wants your password or promises a prize, tell an adult.

Older students (ages 13–15)

- Add advanced tricks: look-alike letters (`schooI.example`), the `@` sign in an address, QR codes.
- Discuss why scam messages no longer have spelling mistakes (artificial intelligence).
- Mission *Responding to phishing*: what to do when a classmate entered their password on a fake site.

Things to watch out for

- Teach students to tell the difference, not to be afraid. Not every email is a scam; every inbox in the app also contains real messages.
- If a student says they already entered a password somewhere, help them change it right away and inform the administrator according to school rules, without shaming.
- If your school has a "Report phishing" button or an administrator's email, show students where to find it.

WORKSHEET · SAMPLE LESSON 2

Email Detective

Name and class: _____

All messages and addresses on this sheet are made up.

1. Circle everything suspicious

From: Super Prizes <prize@super-gifts.test>
Subject: CONGRATULATIONS! You won a tablet!

Hi,

you won a new tablet! We will send it to you if you log in within 30 minutes and enter your username and password.

www.school.example/prize (link goes to: https://school.example.win-tablet.test/login)

Don't tell anyone about the prize, or they might take it away.

Attachment: prize_terms.pdf.exe

How many suspicious signs did you find? _____

2. Where does the link go?

Write the real domain (right before the first slash) and circle whether it goes to the school `school.example`.

Address	Real domain	Is it the school?
`https://school.example/timetable`		yes / no
`https://school.example.grades-info.test/`		yes / no
`https://portal.school.example/grades`		yes / no
`https://school-example.test/login`		yes / no

3. What do you do? Match each situation with the right response (write the letter).

Situation	Letter
1. An email says your account will be deleted within an hour unless you enter your password.	
2. A friend sends you a chat message, "Look, is this you in the video?", and it sounds strange.	
3. You clicked a link by mistake and entered your password.	
4. A text message says you must pay $1 for a parcel.	

A Tell an adult right away and change the password on the official website. **B** Don't click, and ask the friend another way, for example in person. **C** Enter nothing, report the message and show it to an adult. **D** Pay nothing, show it to my parents and check the parcel on the delivery company's website.

4. Exit ticket

Write three signs that tell you an email is a scam:

_____

_____

_____

FOR THE TEACHER · SAMPLE LESSON 2

Worksheet answers

1. Suspicious signs (7)

- The sender address `super-gifts.test` belongs to neither the school nor a known company.
- The subject and text promise a prize (bait).
- Rushing: “within 30 minutes”.
- A request for a username and password.
- The link text looks like the school’s, but the link goes to the domain `win-tablet.test`.
- A request for secrecy: “Don’t tell anyone about the prize”.
- The attachment `.pdf.exe` is a program, not a document.

The greeting “Hi” is not suspicious on its own. If students circle it, explain that what matters is what the message asks for.

2. Where does the link go?

Address	Real domain	Is it the school?
`https://school.example/timetable`	school.example	yes
`https://school.example.grades-info.test/`	grades-info.test	no
`https://portal.school.example/grades`	school.example (portal is part of it)	yes
`https://school-example.test/login`	school-example.test	no

3. What do you do?

1 – C, 2 – B, 3 – A, 4 – D

4. Exit ticket

Accept any three signs from the list on page 1 (rushing, a prize, a request for a password or details, a strange link, an unexpected attachment, secrecy, a fake sender address).

Follow-up activities: at home with their parents, students find out where to report a scam message in their email; in the next lesson they complete another level of Email Detective. Related topic: *A strong password from random words* (sample lesson 1).